

console was an immediate success though. The public had seen one *Pong* knock-off too many, and both companies faced major losses in the beginning.

Fairchild pulled out of the market while Atari stuck on. The move paid off, and when the public realised it was possible to play games other than *Pong*, sales took off. The 2600 sold well right into the '80s, selling well over eight million units. In fact, many gamers fondly refer to it as the console that never died. Even today, enthusiasts make games for the 2600, and collect old games. Over its lifetime, a reported 25 million units were sold, with a games library of over 900 titles.

Atari had also released updated versions of the 2600 to capitalise on its success (the 2700, 2800 and the 2600 Jr.), but none were ever as popular, or acquired cult status the way the original 2600 did.

The next two years saw the release of the Magnavox Odyssey 2 and the Milton-Bradley Microvision, in successive years. Both enjoyed moderate success without setting the industry alight. The next milestone was the release of the Mattel Intellivision in 1980. Developed by Mattel Electronics (a subsidiary of Mattel Toys), it was the very first console to successfully challenge the supremacy of the Atari 2600. Excellent marketing was a big reason behind this, as were superior hardware capabilities. A series of advertisements highlighting the superiority of the Intellivision as compared to the 2600 really hurt the latter.

In many ways the Intellivision was a pioneer, setting the standards for others to follow. It was the first 16-bit console, and the first to provide real-time voices via an add-on peripheral called the Intellivoice, which was made specifically for that purpose. All this meant that during its 12-year run, three million consoles were sold and over 125 games released.

Once again, the next few years saw a number of consoles, none of which did spectacularly. Among these was the very first